Snippet presentation

Object drop in Vietnamese

Clara Tran

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1 Background: pronouns

- Pronouns can be classified as either *overt* or *covert* in terms of their explicitness in a sentence.
- **Overt** pronouns are explicitly present in the sentence structure, whereas **covert** pronouns require grammatical or contextual clues to indicate who or what is being referenced.
- English is non-pro-drop as it relies heavily on overt pronouns.
  (1) I am going to the market.
- Other languages, like Spanish or Vietnamese, are pro-drop and use covert pronouns more frequently.
  (2) Voy al mercado.
  go.1SG to the market
  'I'm going to the market.'
  (3) Đi chợ.
  go market
  'I'm going to the market.'

2 Subject drop: Spanish and Vietnamese

2.1. Spanish: Alonso-Ovalle et al. (2002)

- Null pronouns tend to prefer linking to more syntactically prominent antecedents, such as subjects, compared to overt pronouns.

(4) *Two-sentence discourse*

a. Juan pegó a Pedro. (pro) está enfadado.
Juan hit Pedro pro is tired
'Juan$_1$ hit Pedro. He$_1$ is tired.' (73.2%)

b. Juan pegó a Pedro. Él está enfadado.
Juan hit Pedro he is tired
'Juan$_1$ hit Pedro. He$_1$ is tired.' (50.2%)

(5) *Variable binding*

a. Ningún estudiante cre que (pro) pasó el examen.
No student believes that pro passed the exam
'No student$_1$ believes that he$_1$ passed the exam.' (86,9%)

b. Ningún estudiante cre que él pasó el examen.
No student believes that he passed the exam
'No student$_1$ believes that he$_1$ passed the exam.' (63,3%)

- This suggests a **division of labour** in terms of anaphora resolution: *pro* is more sensitive to the syntactic position of antecedents, while overt pronouns do not exhibit the same level of sensitivity to syntactic prominent.
- Such these findings are consistent with Carminati's (2002) **Position of Antecedent Hypothesis (PAH)**: *pro* prefers to retrieve an antecedent in the (highest) Spec IP, whereas (overt) pronouns prefer an antecedent in a lower syntactic position.

2.2. Vietnamese subject drop

- Subject drop in Vietnamese behaves similarly to what PAH predicts.

(6) *Intra-sentential subject drop*

a. Nam nói là (pro) không thấy Lan.
Nam say that pro NEG-see Lan
'Nam$_1$ said that he$_1$ did not see Lan.'

b. Nam nói là anh ấy không thấy Lan.
Nam say that 3sg.M NEG-see Lan
'Nam$_1$ said that he$_{1/2}$ did not see Lan.'

(7) *Inter-sentential subject drop*

a. Hôm qua Vân gặp Lan.
yesterday Vân meet Lan
Lúc đó (pro) đang ngồi uống nước.
at that time pro PROG sit drink water
'Yesterday, Vân$_1$ met Lan$_2$. At that time, she$_{1/?2}$ was sitting and drinking water.'

b. Hôm qua Vân gặp Lan.
yesterday Vân meet Lan
Lúc đó cô ấy đang ngồi uống nước.
at that time 3sg.F PROG sit drink water
'Yesterday, Vân$_1$ met Lan$_2$. At that time, she$_{1/2}$ was sitting and drinking water.'

(8) *Variable bounding*

a.	Không ai	nghĩ	(pro)	sẽ	thắng	cuộc thi
	No-one	think	pro	will	win	competition

'No one$_1$ thinks he$_1$ will win this competition.'

b.	Không ai	nghĩ	anh ấy	sẽ	thắng	cuộc thi
	No-one	think	3sg.M	will	win	competition

'No one$_1$ thinks he$_{2/?1}$ will win this competition.'

3 The puzzle: Object drop in Vietnamese

- PAH cannot accurately account for object drop in Vietnamese.

(9) *Intra-sentential object drop*

a.	Vân	nói	là	Lan	không thấy	(pro).
	Vân	say	that	Lan	NEG-see	pro
b.	Vân	nói	là	Lan	không thấy	cô ấy.
	Vân	say	that	Lan	NEG-see	3sg.F

'Vân$_1$ said that Lan$_2$ did not see her$_{1/2/3}$.'

(10) *Inter-sentential object drop*

a.	Hôm qua	Vân	gặp	Lan.		
	yesterday	Vân	meet	Lan		
	Lúc đó Nga	đang	giúp	(pro)	làm	bài tập.
	at that time	PROG	help	pro	do	homework
b.	Hôm qua	Vân	gặp	Lan.		
	yesterday	Vân	meet	Lan		
	Lúc đó Nga	đang	giúp	cô ấy	làm	bài tập.
	at that time	PROG	help	3sg.F	do	homework

'Yesterday, Vân$_1$ met Lan$_2$. At that time, Nga was helping her$_{1/2}$ do homework.'

(11) *Variable bounding*

a.	Không ai	nghĩ	Lan	nhìn thấy	(pro).
	No-one	think	Lan	see	pro
b.	Không ai	nghĩ	Lan	nhìn thấy	anh ấy/cô ấy.
	No-one	think	Lan	see	3sg.M/3sg.F

'No one$_1$ thinks Lan$_2$ saw them$_{1/2/3}$.'

My proposal: Subject drop and object drop in Vietnamese requires different analyses.

4 Side quest: honorifics in Vietnamese

- Honorifics are titles or forms of address used to show respect, politeness, or social status when referring to or addressing someone.
- Vietnamese pronouns are based on kinship terms, so its honorifics indicate the relationship between the speaker and the addressee/the referent (third person).
    - Ông (M) / Bà (F) >> Bác (M/F) >> Cô (F) / Chú (M) >> Anh (M) / Chị (F)
    - Thầy (M)/ Cô (F): teachers
- When referring to a third person, a speaker can either use the same honorific that the listener uses, or drop that honorific, especially if the speaker is older than the person being referred to.

  (12)

A:	Ngày mai	anh Nam	đến	chơi.		
	tomorrow	HON-Nam	come	play		
	'Tomorrow, Nam is coming here to hang out.'					
A's mother:	Thế	anh Nam/nó	có	ở lại	ăn cơm	không?
	so	HON-Nam/3sg	have	stay	eat-rice	Q
	'Is he staying for dinner?'					

How can we account for such these honorifics in formal semantics?

- In English, [[Mr.]] = ∃x. male(x) & Mr.(x) 'there exists a male individual x who is referred to with the honorific "Mr."'

- In Vietnamese:
    - [[Ông]] = ∃x. male(x) & older(x, speaker) & Ông(x)
    - [[Anh]] = ∃x. male(x) & slightly-older(x, speaker) & Anh(x)

- Is it possible to alter the denotation of one honorific when the speaker chooses to maintain whatever the listener uses?
    - [[Anh]] = ∃x. male(x) & slightly-older(x, **listener**) & Anh(x)

5 References

Alonso-Ovalle, Luis; Charles Clifton, Lyn Frazier and Susana Fernández Solera. 2002. Null *vs.* Overt Pronouns and The Topic-Focus Articulation in Spanish. *Journal of Italian Linguistics*, 14:2, pp. 151-169.

Carminati, Maria Nella. 2002. The processing of Italian subject pronouns. Doctoral Dissertation, University of Massachusetts, Amherst, Amherst, MA.